

Children for SALE



The Kosi floods open up a huge 'market' of children to merchants of misery who buy them for a pittance and sell them as slave labour.

By Amitabh Srivastava in Saharsa and Madhepura



Photographs by KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN

Eight-year-old Laltu has the face of an angel. But a closer look reveals there is no sparkle in his eyes; he seems to be lost in thought. After all, there has been much to think about: hours of hunger, the burns inflicted on his buttocks, the excruciating pain and the inability to sleep or even sit for weeks on end.

The ordeal began in September last year, just after the Kosi floods when his father, Gosai Yadav of Gamharia village in Saharsa district, forced Laltu into working at a tea shop after the floods left him with little income. A neighbour then picked him up for Rs 1,200 to be sold again to a farmer in Punjab through Maheswari Yadav, a middleman. Thankfully, however, Laltu escaped in January and after much misadventure, finally managed to come back to his parents (*see box*). Chilling as it may seem, Laltu's family considers it fortunate that he is back with them as there

are many other children of his age who have been trafficked out of their homes in Bihar after the Kosi floods. But hope remains elusive for them.

The Kosi floods have proved to be catastrophic in more ways than one as they have opened up a huge 'market' of children—close to three lakh—to the merchants of misery who have been buying them for sums as low as Rs 500 from their vulnerable families. "Child trafficking is not a recent phenomenon in this part of Bihar which has the lowest per capita income in the state. But it became rampant in the aftermath of the Kosi floods," says Ghuran Mahto, convener of the Bihar unit of the Bachpan Bachao Andolan (BBA), a Delhi-based child rights organisation.